Transcript: AI moderation for an election-candidate contribution site

User

Suppose someone wanted to set up a web site open to contributions from users regarding candidates for an upcoming election. The site will welcome contributions that add information to the site (justified by links to sources) but will reject mere opinion (never mind invective). Rejections will be accompanied by suggestions as to how a contribution might be made acceptable. I imagine that a model such as yourself would be capable of making the distinction and serving as a moderator. Is that right?

Claude

[Claude ran three web searches.]

Largely yes, with an important distinction between the two jobs the moderator would be doing.

Telling information from opinion is the easier job. Distinguishing "Candidate X voted against HB 1234 on March 3 [link to the roll call]" from "Candidate X is a disgrace" is something a model like me does reliably. Explaining a rejection constructively is also a strength, for example: "Your claim that she 'doesn't care about schools' is opinion. If you can link her votes on education funding, state those votes and let readers draw conclusions." The published evidence on this kind of rule-following moderation is encouraging, though it's based on older models than the ones available now. In one study, GPT-3.5 was prompted with the rules of 95 Reddit communities and achieved a median accuracy of 64% and a median precision of 83% [1]. Your rule is cleaner than most subreddit rules, which should help.

Checking that the source supports the claim is the harder job. It requires the moderator to actually fetch and read the linked page rather than trust the link. Even then, it is error-prone. On a benchmark built specifically for this task, even a fine-tuned GPT-3.5 reached only about 80% macro-F1, and most failures came from missing nuanced details [2]. -- Current models do better, but I wouldn't promise near-perfect accuracy. Paywalls, dead links, PDFs of legislation, and video sources add further friction.

The gray zones are where your policy matters more than the model:

- **Disguised opinion.** "Voted against veterans" can be literally true of an omnibus bill containing one veterans' provision. Is a characterization of a vote acceptable, or only the bill name and outcome?

- **Opinion sources.** Is an op-ed acceptable evidence for "Columnist Y argued Z," but not for Z itself?
- **Selective truth.** Every individual contribution can be accurate while the site as a whole becomes lopsided, simply because one camp's supporters contribute more. No per-item moderator can fix that.
- **Adversarial input.** Submissions or linked pages may contain text designed to manipulate an AI moderator.

Bias deserves active testing, not assumption. Researchers found that giving models ideological personas introduced subtle biases into harmful-content classification, and in politically targeted tasks the models judged criticism of their ideological in-group more harshly than criticism of opponents [3]. That study induced bias deliberately through personas, so it doesn't show that a neutrally prompted moderator would behave this way. But it argues for checks you can run yourself. One is mirrored test submissions: the same claim with the candidates' names or parties swapped, which should get the same verdict.

A practical design would include:

- a structured submission form with the claim, the URL, and the exact passage that supports it;
- a model check that the passage exists at the URL and supports the claim without overreaching;
- a published rubric;
- a log of decisions;
- a human appeal path.

Counterargument. Some would argue that automated moderation of election content is unwise however accurate it is. Legitimacy depends on contributors believing the referee is fair. A rejection from a visible, accountable human panel may be accepted where the same rejection from an AI fuels claims of algorithmic bias. Error rates that are tolerable for forum spam also matter more when each mistake can be framed as suppressing one side. The usual reply is a hybrid: the model triages and drafts feedback, and humans decide disputed cases.

References

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User

Yes, the ultimate decision to accept or reject a contribution could come from a human moderator (I'm not envisioning a crushing number of contributions). The model could serve mostly in an educational role, guiding users to useful contributions and perhaps offering counterpoints to arguments.

Models such as yourself are powered by the enormous resources of Anthropic or similar. Is it possible for a tech savvy but money-stressed person to make use of a model that has the requisite ability but not the general data resources of models such as yourself?

Claude

[Claude ran five web searches and one attempted page fetch.]

Yes, and it's probably cheaper than you'd expect. Training a model takes enormous resources, but that cost is paid once by whoever trains it. Running a trained model on your own workload costs very little. Your task also doesn't depend much on the model's stored general knowledge: the material it judges is the contribution plus the source page it fetches. What you need is careful reading and judgment, and capable small models have that.

There are three realistic routes.

1. Rent a small commercial model by the request. This is the easiest and probably the cheapest in total cost. (I'm made by Anthropic, so I'll note that OpenAI, Google and others sell comparable small models.) As an example, Claude Haiku 5.5 launched at $0.10 per million input tokens and $0.50 per million output tokens for prompts under 100,000 tokens, with higher rates above that [1]. A contribution plus a fetched source page might total about 10,000 input tokens, with about 1,000 tokens of feedback. That works out to roughly a tenth of a cent to a fifth of a cent per submission, or about $1–2 per thousand submissions. You need no hardware, only an API key and some glue code on your server.

2. Run an open-weight model on your own machine. Ollama is free, open-source software, and every model in its library is open-weight, so running them costs nothing beyond hardware and electricity, with no per-token fees [2]. A commonly cited practical minimum is 16GB of unified memory on a Mac or 12GB of VRAM on a PC [3]. If you already own such a machine, the cost is close to zero. If you'd have to buy one, the API route stays cheaper for years at your volume. Models that fit on consumer hardware are noticeably weaker at nuance, though. That matters most for the educational role, where the model drafts counterpoints and explains why something reads as opinion.

3. Use a specialized small checker for the source-verification step. Researchers have shown you don't need a large model just to answer "does this source support this claim?" The MiniCheck authors built small fact-checking models with GPT-4-level performance at 400 times lower cost. Their best model, MiniCheck-FT5 at 770M parameters, outperforms all systems of comparable size and reaches GPT-4 accuracy, and the models are publicly released [4]. A model that size runs on an ordinary computer. One cheap design pairs MiniCheck for verification with a modest general model, local or rented, for detecting opinion and writing feedback.

Whichever route you choose, a few costs aren't about the model at all. Reliably fetching source pages (paywalls, PDFs, dead links) is often more work than the AI part. You'd also want to run the mirrored-submission bias tests mentioned earlier, especially with a small local model.

Counterargument. Some would say the "money-stressed" framing points the wrong way. At your volume, the API costs pennies a month, while the local route costs your time: setup, upkeep, and model updates. Time is usually the scarcer resource. The opposing case is about control rather than money. With an API, the vendor can change prices, retire models, or alter behavior without notice. A local open-weight model is frozen and fully under your control, which some would value for a site whose fairness must be inspectable and stable through an election cycle.

References

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